

The AI Gold Rush Trap

What 1,000 live indie businesses reveal about where founders should actually build next

By Kartikey Thussu · Section B, SMG · Source: TrustMRR, frozen 30 Jul 2026

The Question Every Founder Asks

“I want to build something — I just can’t figure out what.”

01

What's crowded

Where are 1,000 builders piling in?

02

What's paying

Which categories & buyers become real MRR?

03

What to build

Where's the gap between hype and yield?

THE EVIDENCE BASE

1,000 Live Businesses. Real Revenue. No Guesswork.

1,000

Live indie startups

29

Data points tracked per company

3+

Verified payment providers
(Stripe, Polar, RevenueCat...)

30 Jul

2026 — dataset frozen

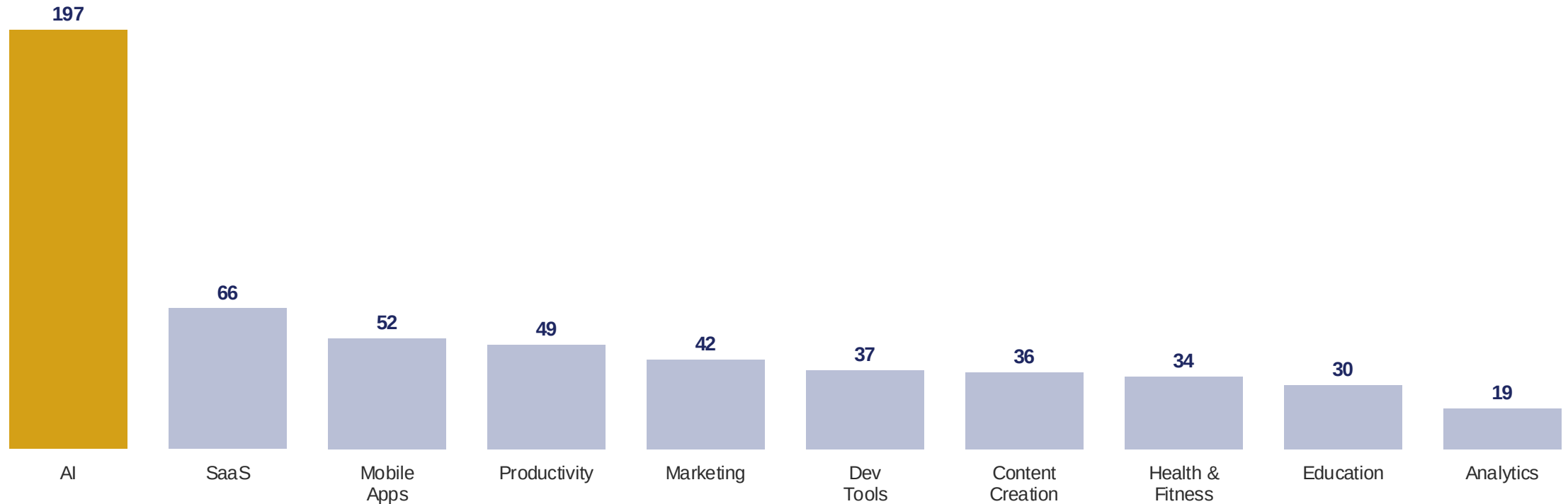
Every row is a real business with connected payment data — not a survey, not a press release. Revenue and buyer type are measured, not self-reported.

PART ONE

Everyone's Mining AI

AI Is the Most Crowded Category — By Far

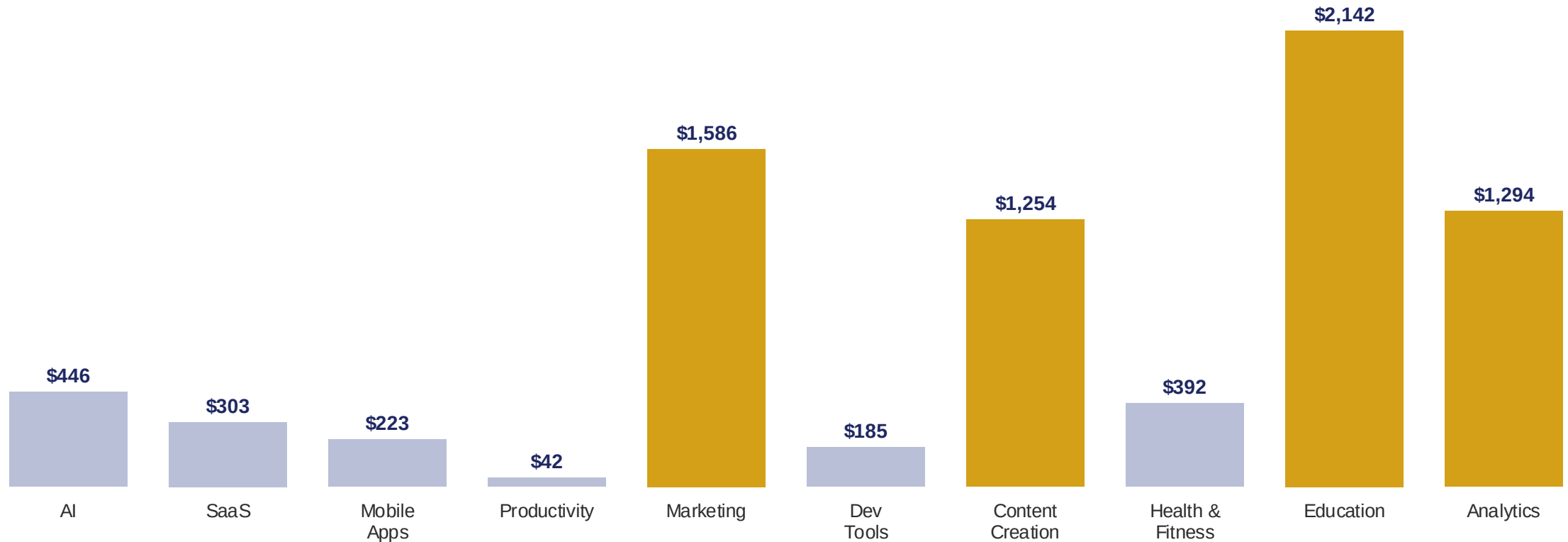
197 of 1,000 builders — nearly 1 in 5 — picked AI as their category



THE TWIST

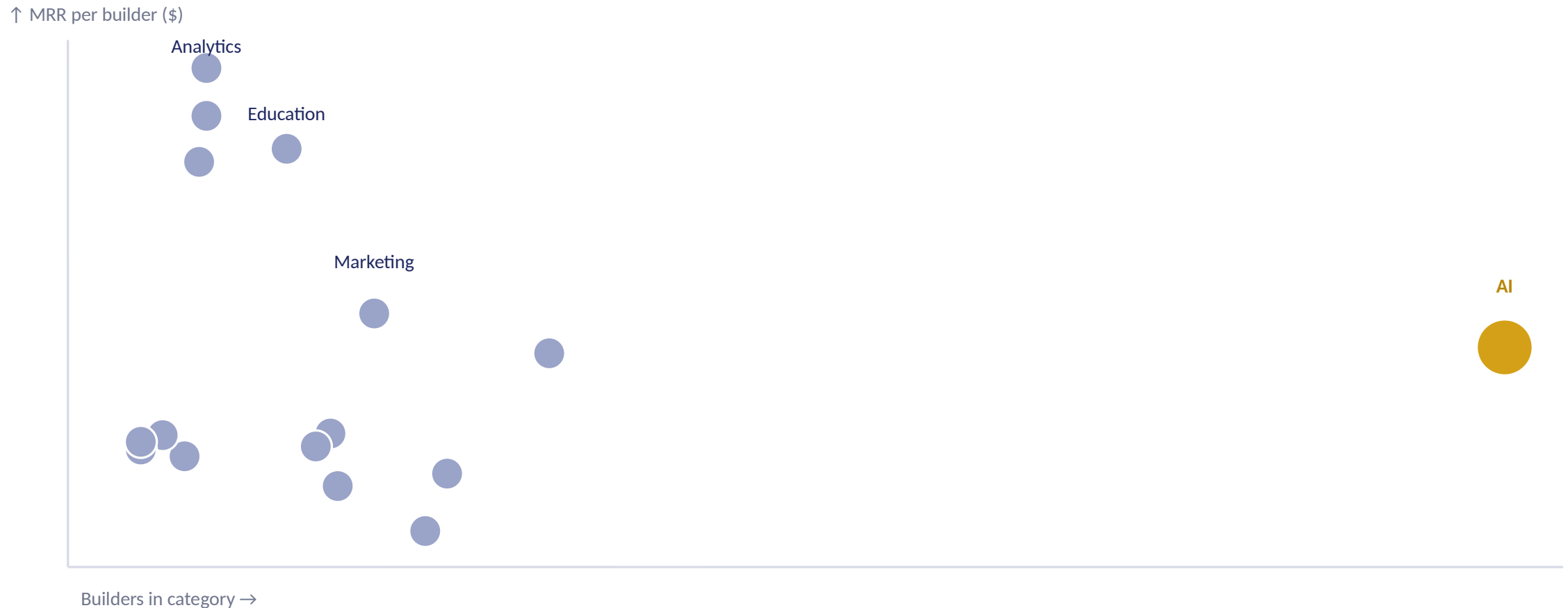
But Median Revenue Doesn't Reward the Crowd

AI's median MRR is \$446 — behind Marketing, Content Creation, Education & Analytics



Builder Count vs. Revenue Per Builder

Bottom-right = crowded & low-yield. Top-left = fewer builders, bigger payout.



PART TWO

Even Inside AI, Most Builders Are Mining Wrong

AI Founders Split Almost Evenly — B2C vs B2B

88 consumer AI products vs. 75 B2B — nearly a coin flip

88

B2C AI

75

B2B AI

But B2B AI Earns Almost 5x More

\$277

B2C AI — median MRR

\$1,357

B2B AI — median MRR

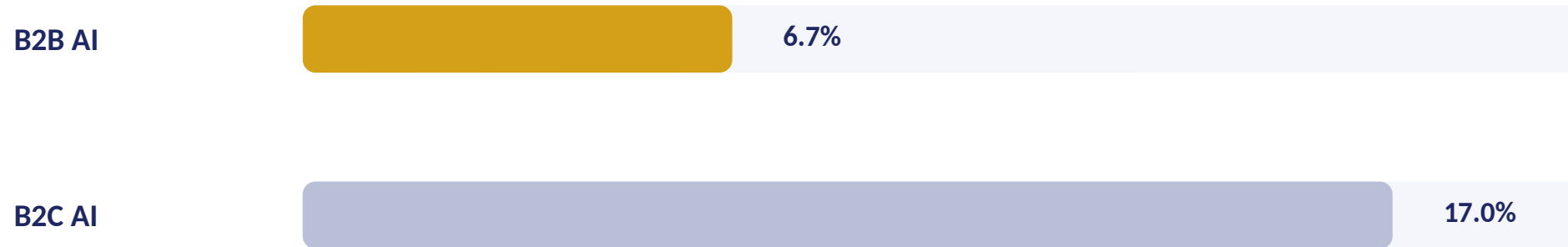
4.9× the revenue

Same category, same tools, wildly different buyer economics.

THE RISK

Consumer AI Also Fails More Often

Share of companies earning literally \$0/month in MRR



Building a consumer AI product is roughly 2.5x more likely to end at zero revenue than building for a business buyer.

THE WINNERS

The Winners Share One Trait: A Narrow Buyer

Top-earning AI companies by MRR — all sell to a specific, painful workflow

GojiberryAI	\$494,668	Sales teams & outbound agencies
PROSP	\$128,005	Agencies & sales teams
Upscale System	\$86,543	B2B agencies & founder-led sales
SEOBOT	\$49,691	Project-busy founders
WaLead AI	\$28,494	Lead-gen agencies & GTM teams

PART THREE

Where the Real Yield Is

THE ALTERNATIVE

Smaller Categories, Bigger Paychecks

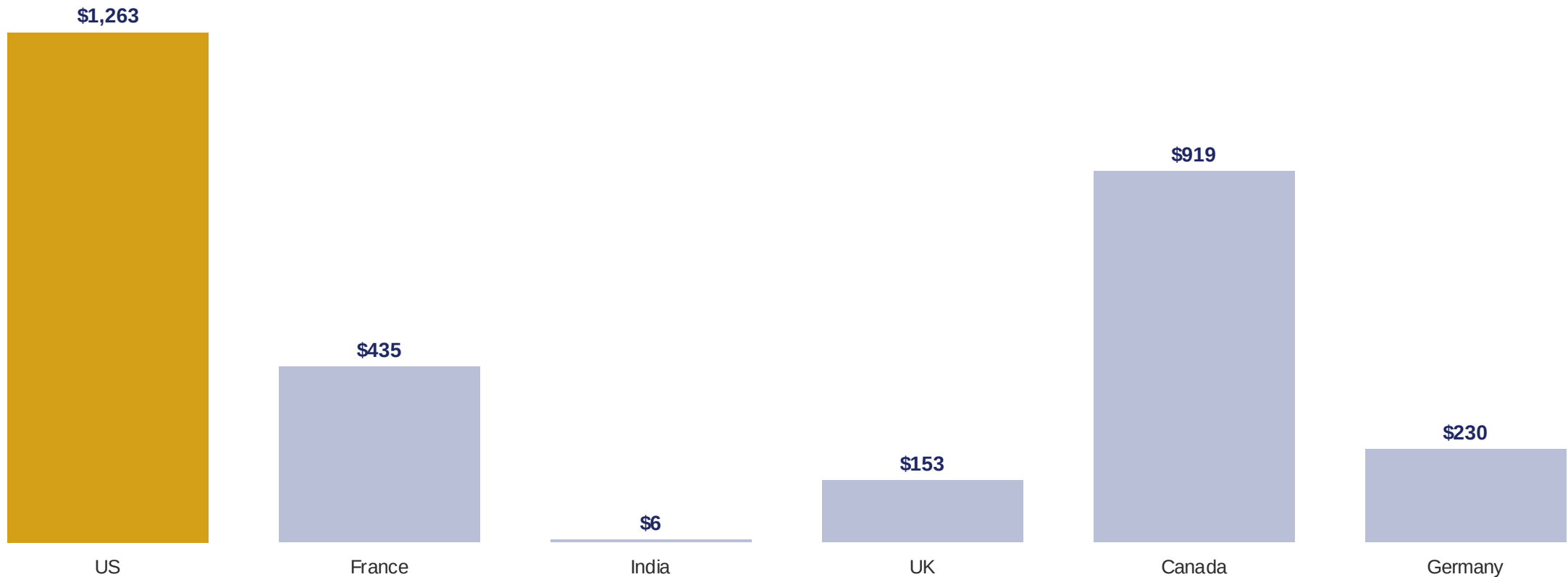
Revenue generated per builder — total category MRR ÷ number of companies

CATEGORY	BUILDERS	MRR PER BUILDER
AI	197	\$9,167
Marketing	42	\$10,583
Customer Support	5	\$13,787*
Analytics	19	\$18,831
Education	30	\$17,458

**Customer Support has only 5 companies in the dataset — directional, not conclusive.*

More Builders Doesn't Mean More Revenue Either

Median MRR by country — India has the 3rd-most builders and near-zero revenue



PART FOUR

The Investment Thesis

Don't build in AI.

Build for a narrow B2B buyer — with AI as the tool, not the pitch.

The category everyone rushes into is the category with the worst odds. The winners sell a specific workflow to a specific buyer — AI just happens to be how they built it.

Three Filters Before You Write Code

1

Pick a narrow B2B buyer

Agencies, sales teams, ops — not “everyone.” Narrow buyers pay 5x more.

2

Treat AI as infrastructure

It’s how you build, not what you sell. “AI-powered” is not a business model.

3

Check underbuilt categories first

Education, Analytics & Marketing pay more per builder — with far less competition.

Risks & Caveats

Small samples in niche categories

Customer Support (n=5) and similar categories are directional signals, not statistical proof.

Optional, self-reported fields

Pricing, persona, and market tags are missing for many rows — category and revenue fields are the most complete.

A snapshot, not a trend line

Data is frozen at 30 Jul 2026. It shows what's working now — not causation, not the future.

BACKUP

Appendix

Category Detail (n ≥ 8)

Category	N	Med. MRR	MRR/Builder
AI	197	\$446	\$9,167
SaaS	66	\$303	\$8,920
Mobile Apps	52	\$223	\$3,898
Productivity	49	\$42	\$1,501
Marketing	42	\$1,586	\$10,583
Dev Tools	37	\$185	\$3,378
Content Creation	36	\$1,254	\$5,569
Health & Fitness	34	\$392	\$5,030
Education	30	\$2,142	\$17,458
E-comm	19	\$155	\$20,829

Category	N	Med. MRR	MRR/Builder
Analytics	19	\$1,294	\$18,831
Social Media	18	\$912	\$16,911
Fintech	16	\$500	\$4,620
Sales	13	\$1,036	\$5,505
Design Tools	12	\$83	\$2,290
Real Estate	12	\$96	\$2,059
Utilities	10	\$78	\$4,903
Games	10	\$262	\$5,223
Security	8	\$192	\$4,576
Entertainment	8	\$302	\$12,445

APPENDIX B

Country Detail (Top 12 by Builder Count)

Country	Builders	Median MRR	Total MRR
United States	258	\$1,263	\$7.50M
France	79	\$435	\$894K
India	59	\$6	\$157K
United Kingdom	50	\$153	\$350K
Canada	29	\$919	\$366K
Germany	24	\$230	\$75K
Brazil	20	\$666	\$84K
Hong Kong	19	\$0	\$208K
Australia	17	\$326	\$106K
Spain	16	\$78	\$79K
Poland	15	\$236	\$78K
Netherlands	13	\$0	—

Methodology Notes

- **Median, not mean**

Median MRR is used throughout — a handful of outlier winners (e.g. \$494K MRR) would otherwise distort category comparisons.

- **MRR per builder**

= total category MRR ÷ number of companies in that category. A market-size-normalized view of category productivity.

- **Zero values included**

Companies with \$0 MRR are counted, not excluded — this is what drives the “failure rate” comparisons.

- **“B2B / B2C” field**

“Both” audience-type rows are excluded from the B2B-vs-B2C split slides to keep the comparison clean.

The AI Gold Rush Trap

Build narrow. Build B2B. Let AI be the how, not the what.

Thank you — questions welcome.